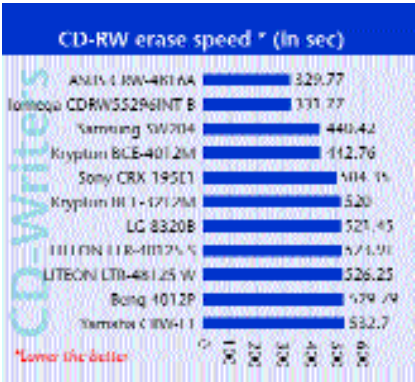




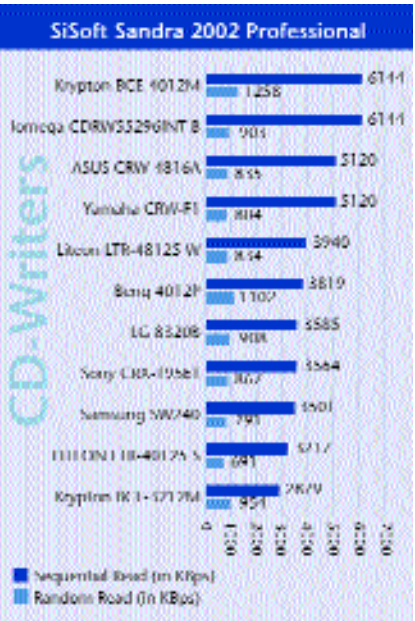
this is at least 10-15 per cent slower than what you should expect.

RW-Erase Speed: In this test, we erased 700 MB of data at the highest speed supported by the drive. Once again the ASUS Writer logged the fastest time (329.77 seconds), just seconds faster than the

Iomega drive (331.77 seconds). The drive which took the longest time was the Yamaha CRW-F1, logging 532.7 seconds. Read tests (CDs): The whole point of installing a CD-Writer is that it serves the dual function of burning data onto CDs and also works as a regular CD-ROM drive. **Assorted Read Speed:** To evaluate the capability of a CD-Writer to read a normal CD-ROM, we tried copying 700 MB of assorted data from the Digit Test CD to the hard disk. The ASUS CRW-4816A completed this task in the fastest time, logging 138.73 seconds—this translates to a data transfer rate of about 5 MBps. The ASUS drive will be best suited for the kind of people who are copying lots of data like images and important work related files on their PC like DTP house, and so on. The slowest here was the LITEON LTR-BCE-4012M, which took 234.31 seconds.

Disk Registration: This test measures the time taken by the OS to recognise the CD. The fastest drive here was the Yamaha CRW-F1 with 8.71 seconds. The LG 8320B was really slow and took 14.7 seconds—long enough to be irritating.

Exact Audio Copy: Here, the first, middle and last track is ripped from an Audio CD to WAV format. The best result was presented by the Yamaha, which ripped all three tracks in 38.04 seconds, followed by the Krypton BCE-3212M (43.38 seconds). The slowest here was the Samsung SW240, which took 38.49 seconds just to rip the middle track; its overall time was 106.2 seconds. If you are planning to buy a drive mainly to rip Audio CDs and also burn data occasionally, the Krypton works out to be a better choice as it is cheaper than the Yamaha.



SiSoft Sandra 2002 Pro: The SiSoft Sandra 2002 Pro benchmarking suite helps determine the different data transfer speeds and the drive access time. In the sequential read test, the Iomega Writer and Krypton BCE-4012M logged 6 MBps. In the random read test, the Kryp-

ton BCE-4012 once again logged the highest data transfer speed of 1258 KBps, crossing the 1 MBps mark. This CD-Writer also returned the fastest average access time, hence making it an ideal candidate for use as a CD-ROM drive. This drive is best for those who want a good CD-ROM drive and also occasionally want to be able to burn CDs. Benq too crossed the 1 MBps mark by logging a random read score of 1100 KBps.

Nero CDSpeed v1.0: The Nero CDSpeed v1.0 benchmarking suite tests the range of speed the drive can reach. It measures both the fastest speed and the slowest, and also gives the average speed of the drive. In this test, the best performer was the Krypton BCE-4012M. It reached a maximum speed of 49.94x, higher than its rated maximum speed of 48x. The slowest speed it logged was 23.33x, which is higher than the other CD-Writers. If you intend to use the CD-Writer to watch VCDs and play AudioCDs and don't mind a slower writing speed, you will find this CD-Writer quite suitable.

DVD-ROM Drives

A DVD-ROM drive is ideal for those who wish to watch theatre-quality movies from the comfort of their living room. Besides, it also reads all optical media and is a better upgrade from the plain CD-ROM drive, since it is a cheaper buy when compared to CD-Writers.

Features

The DVD drives did not offer much in terms of variety in speed—all the drives sported 16x read speed for DVDs, which is currently the fastest speed available, and a 40x to 48x read speed for CDs.

All the DVD-ROM drives we received came with a healthy buffer size, though the buffer space allotted was small compared to the CD-Writers—not surprising, considering that these drives are not meant to burn CDs or DVDs. All drives offered 512 KB buffer, except the Pioneer DVD-106S/2, which had only 256 KB buffer.

Build quality of the tray becomes important here too. The Pioneer drive stood apart from the rest with its slot-in disk-loading mechanism. This imparts a level of sturdiness to the build of this drive that is absent in its competitors. All seven DVD drives featured in this test allowed for vertical usage.

There wasn't much in the name of package content for the DVD drives. Almost all provided an audio cable, but a few like the Pioneer skimped on this. As for the IDE cable, only Samsung and Sony include this. Software bundling came in the form of Asus-DVD 3.0 with the ASUS drive, WinDVD3.1 with the Benq, while

Region Locking

As a part of DVD technology licensing arrangements, the world has been divided into six geographic regions. This means that movies from Region 1 (USA and Canada) will not play on a DVD player designated for regions 2 to 6. Effectively, Region 1 discs play only on Region 1 DVD players, Region 2 discs play only on Region 2 DVD players and so on. A region code is embedded in the DVD-ROM drive. The first DVD disc inserted into a drive sets the region code for the drive. The drive's region can be changed four more times before it is permanently locked to a region. Inserting a disc that has a different region code than the drive's current code makes these changes.